

# An Idiot's Guide to Hedonism

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Draft 1

## Dedication and Disclaimer

This was written as a love story for the small, the stupid, the absurd and the joyful. Some of this is real, some of this is a narration, I originally wanted to do stand-up comedy, but, after thinking about just how terrible it would feel to bomb on stage, I figured I may

## Chapter 1

I was standing in the middle of my favorite restaurant naked and proud. Well, I wasn't quite naked, I was, in fact, wearing a bright neon green speedo. The color contrasted my tan, sculpted hairline, glistening with sweat. The overwhelming smell of basil flooded my nostrils, and I decided that I should probably take a seat. Sitting at the bar, watching the cooks prep a pasta, I made eye contact with Lucy. She's worked here for as long as I've come to this spot, a Toronto classic. She wore her usual outfit, a thin black looking tee, and oversized flowing maroon pants with the staple sambas. Her boring Toronto outfit was contrasted by her blue tattoos of cartoon characters, button nose, dark mysterious complexion, and Korean features. I was openly in love with this married woman.

Sitting there awkwardly smiling, in the loud and bustling restaurant, I felt comfortable.

"Hello hello, it's been a while since I've seen you, have you been avoiding me?" She asked.

"Ever since you dropped the news of your engagement, I went looking for God. I couldn't find him so now I'm back." I replied.

"In the meantime, do you want your usual?"

"Yes please, Luce." As she walked away, she traced her fingers along my left shoulder. How horrible. Next to me sat this older bald man wearing sharply colored orange glasses. The glasses

were thick; this was a decision he actually made. Wow. The rest of his outfit was boring, but as we looked at each other, he raised his eyebrows and smiled ever so slightly. Maybe he wasn't all that bad. He would love my observation about meteorology, I just knew it, and decided to tell him all about rain and pumpkins. But before I could open my gullet, he opened his. "squack". "squack squaw"

This was weird, but not the weirdest thing I've ever experienced. "bark bark" I replied.

He moved so close I could smell his fishy breath, his nose delicately pressing against mine, his hands were on my face, then my chest, and in that moment, I wish I found God instead of coming back for Lucy.

Blinking, I was blinded by the morning light, the seagull, really was right in front of me. Staring at me like dinner. It took me 10 minutes to chase it away with the closest item I had at hand, a spatula. At a different point in my life, I would've considered domesticating it, but this past year I've become too feral to be responsible for anything as majestic as a water bird.

Me on the other hand I was anything but majestic, I really was wearing a speedo, but I wasn't in my favorite restaurant with Lucy, I was home, docked at the Scarborough bluffs. My small boat's living quarters were best described as intimate, with streaks of sunshine streaming in from the door, directly into my face as I lay sprawled on the double sized bed, as a recently single, eligible bachelor.

To my left was the kitchenette, a small closet, and a door to the washroom, with its own shower. The walls weren't bare; they were overcrowded with photographs and paintings. Each photograph was a study of the human condition, friends, family, strangers, and inanimate objects were scattered across the wall in what I called a clusterfuck formation.

Squinting, I could faintly make out a picture of my best friend from elementary school holding up a fish, and an old neighbour pouring ceremonial tea. The paintings were made up squarely of unrealistic depictions of hell. One was of a dad pushing his

daughter on the swings, beaming, another was of a collection of smokestacks in northern Macedonia. The sunshine dressing the colorful homes in a glow.

Having chased away the seagull successfully I used the remainder of my fleeting, hungover willpower, to lay back down on the bed and unlock my phone. Shit. I forgot to charge the thing. That's a miracle in disguise though; I'll have the chance to limit my doomscrolling down to just 13% of battery before my phone dies and I'm forced to start my day. What a treat.

I do this thing, that I'm sure is unique to me, where I rotate between apps on my phone, I call it the checking the fridge method. You start with the main course: Instagram. I open it and scroll until I start to breath shallowly, then, once I start to feel like I could watch another 10 dog videos I surprise myself with the Mail. I delete the daily junk mail, and after going through my 8 email accounts I settle onto Facebook. I lowball 6 boat listings, and reply yes it's available in multiple languages I barely of grasp, like German and Spanish. Nein nein nein. One week I only replied in Swahili, its like Duolingo, but funnier, and real people terrorize you instead of an imaginary owl. Once that's done I return to Instagram, where after scrolling through 10 facts I need to hear before I'm 40, a man eating paint, and a cover of a billy joel song, I land on something my hungover brain wanted, no, needed. A video of a tree. I don't know the first thing about trees, and the account it came from was Japanese. It made no sense, but from what I could grasp from the English comments, this tree was found at the top of a hike in Kyoto. Something about this tree made smile, it felt serene. As serene as a tree could be. I screenshotted the tree and the comment with the location before zoning out staring at the pile of laundry on the ground, I wonder what the calories of that eating a shirt would be, and would it change depending on whether I boil it or burn it?

It was just past 9am now, and I was hungry. I changed out of the speedo. And put on adult clothes, normal jeans, and a normal gray tee, and sneakers. Wheezing a little as I put on the shoes, I realized that it's been a while since I've exercised, it's been at least

a week. Tomorrow. Balancing the knot of the left shoe, making it aesthetic and symmetrical, I push through my leg and stand up so fast I hit my head against the light above me. It hurt a little, but not enough to stop me from conquering breakfast.

I stepped out onto the deck into a humid Toronto summer. Walking out of the marina I realized that I forgot my car keys. 10 minutes later I was sitting in the car, with the maps app tracing a confident line towards my breakfast place. I drove up a steep hill, around a bend, only hit one cyclist, honked at two red lights and parked before I knew it. Is this what living on automatic feels like? As I walked through the diner doors, I felt intense pride wash over me as I saw all the regulars scattered across tables meant for 4, filled with old men like me.

“Didn’t think you’d make it out until lunch time” said a slim Ethiopian man with beady eyes small mouth, and huge plate of pancakes and cereal bathing in chocolate milk.

“Good morning, Jim, you know I wouldn’t miss this breakfast if I woke up in Manitoba, I’d find a way” I said as I parked my bony buttock in the booth across from him. Beep beep boop.

“What’ll you be having?” “A hungry man with extra peameal and extra French toast please.”

“Of course,” said the young man taking my order, his name was Jack and he was doing this job against his will, his parents said they wouldn’t pay his university tuition if he didn’t work every summer. He’s never dropped a single coffee as far as I’ve ever seen. I think he wants to be an accountant, what great ambition.

Looking over Jim, I struggled to think,

“I love this city man, I think it’s the best place in the world. But it’s missing something very specific. If you can guess what it is, I will buy your breakfast”

“You never let up with these kinds of games do you man? Well, based on all the conversations we’ve ever had, I think it’s missing better food.”

“Food, come on Jim, no way, what you’re missing is better taste”

“I have a long ride planned, you can go ahead and suck it. Okay, not food, more beautiful people, with a sense of style?”

“That’s a better guess, but no, it’s not the women, or the food, or the drugs, that’s all readily available in this wonderful city. No, what it’s missing is cultural depth, that grandiosity that a thousand-year-old tree can give.”

“Okay mister high and mighty, I see you’re still scared of going back to see Lucy. Fair enough. But you’re completely wrong, we’ve got so many cultures here, the only thing that limits the depth is your willingness to interact with them, have you ever come to dinner at my house for example? No. If you did, you’d appreciate a new culture without some old cross or something.”

I stared at Jim for a solid few seconds, my food arrived and I didn’t want to argue, it would be pointless, instead, I focused on the breakfast in front of me, 3 sunny side eggs with hollandaise sauce, 4 slices of challa bread drowned in a secret egg and milk mixture creating the fluffiest french toast on earth, perfectly crispy home fries with finely chopped spring onion, and a small mountain of bacon. I’m celebrating being alive I told myself.

After showering the army of crispy potato in Ketchup and salsa verde, I got to work on raping and pillaging the food, while thinking of anything that might get under Jim’s skin, and then a trojan horse stomped right into my head.

“How’re the wife and kids? You must be so proud of how of how healthy and fit she’s gotten lately, that personal trainer of hers is really good, an example of a young fit man with character.”

“Yes, she’s really good, and yeah, he’s been incredible, he’s even helped me with fueling properly before my long rides. Too bad he’s only into men and not bi, we’d have loved to have invited him to dinner”

“How did you find out he was gay?”

“You know Dominique, she’s like a detective, all she needs is a first name and a description and before you know it she can probably figure out your social number, childhood trauma, and sexual orientation in one Instagram scroll.” Foiled. There goes any chance of an angry Jim choking on cereal red faced. Fuck. No wait.

“How come I’ve never been invited before?”

“Why do you think you woke up in a green speedo buddy?”

“NO. How come I can’t remember? Was it mind shatteringly good?”

“You decided to roofie yourself before coming over you told us, fuck man I thought you were joking.”

“Psyche, of course I remember! Come on man why wouldn’t I want to remember my best friend and his wife naked.” I didn’t fucking remember shit. I zoned back in on the bacon, lathered it in syrup, and crunched on them like a barnyard animal. I laughed at myself and chocked on a piece of bacon a little before it forced its way down. Survival of the fittest, the bacon stood no chance.

“Jim, I’m going to Kyoto to look at a tree. I saw this one shrine at the top of a mountain, Fushimi Inari-taisha is what it’s called I think, I saw it on Instagram this morning, and there was something about it, something important about it. It made me shed a tear man.”

“I don’t know what kind of drugs you had last night, but before you leave find out and get me some, the sex didn’t leave me as enlightened as it did you clearly.”

“No doubt.”

There it was, the moment it was all about to change I told myself. Sitting there in front of my best friend in what I now see as a post coital glow, I saw my future flash before my eyes, depth, revelation, secrets, and if I squinted really really hard, the outlines of Dominique.

## Chapter 2

I was Snickers driving, its thing I do where I put Snickers bars into my mouth like a hippopotamus while driving with my other hand. It works because its not drinking and its not drugs. If anything more people should do this, it keeps your blood sugar high while driving mellowing you out. Snarly. Stopped at the intersection I realized that the good citizen thing to do would be to always keep a few spare chocolate bars in the car and to throw them into the passenger side of anyone who decides to honk angrily next time I take a little too long to drive again when the lights change, that way they can learn to chill out a little. It's been two days since I've drugged myself and had intercourse with my best friend's wife and him and more importantly since I've first had the idea to visit Kyoto. Getting out of the car like a gangster, I walked into the dollar store, determined to leave with a criminal number of chocolate bars, I put my shades on just in case a kid saw me and wanted to see me as a role model, "That cool grown up is exactly what I want to be who I want to be when I grew up". See this is the thing that most adults forget, as long as you build something useful and successful and sell the business for a lot of money, you can do just about anything you want, like buy

50 Snickers bars to throw into annoying drivers. Yes, this was a legal thought. I'm fine. I also grabbed minty fresh gum, because I was going to visit Lucy outside of my dreams.

I spent the rest of the afternoon packing. Passport, check. Credit card, check. Tiedie shirt, check. Highschool certificate, check. The usual culprits of socks, underwear, dress shirts, a suit set and shorts, check. "So, you're really going on this trip aren't you then? I thought you were kidding." Lucy told me, laying in my bed like some sort of goddess, her eyes twinkling with curiosity and deep-seated pride. See, I made her happy. We're happy together. "Yes, I have to find the meaning of life Luce, ever since that Instagram reel I haven't been able to get it out of my mind. I keep picturing how peaceful I'll feel, maybe it'll help me get over my childhood trauma or magically cure my need for drugs and women." "Are you telling me you're not just seeing me? Why am I not so surprised." She said playfully, finally standing up, next to me, wrapping her arms around my chest, nibbling my ear, then biting down harder than I expected. How horrible. I ignored her, she gets restless when I do that and zip up the top of my suitcase. I turn right around and blow raspberries on her chest, and before she can get pissed off, I head straight for the shower like a trooper invading a rainforest, inviting her to join me. "Did I tell you how I fought off a seagull the size of an eagle a few days ago?"

One of the things I'm going to miss about this city, is definitely the traffic, at least when I'm not alone in the car. Honk. "Here throw this Snickers into that car when they try to pass us" I tell Lucy, passing the chocolate bar to her, "Are you crazy, of course you're serious, why would I believe you wouldn't have me doing something ludicrous like this. Never a free ride to work from you huh?" She said, laughing, staring at me like her helw. "Do it do it do it." I squeak, excited to see my big plans executed in reality by a beautiful woman.

The car honking was a fully blacked out Land Defender, the driver was a middle-aged blonde woman with what looks like a curly perm, in the back of the car Luce could faintly make out children. She waved her arm down to the kids, it made more sense throwing something at the driver, that would be legitimately dangerous,

“Think fast! This is for your mom!” Lucy threw two chocolate bars at the 13-year-old boy in the back seat, instead of acting like a kid, he smirked and made a sour face, as if we were gifting him a radish. This kid deserved a radish not a chocolate bar.

“Good girl, you did it. I didn’t think you honestly had it in you.” As we stopped at the next light, I gave her a deep kiss, tasting a bit of chocolate.

“When did you get a chance to have a chocolate bar”

“Who said I had any chocolate, you’re crazy.” She said, smiling broadly. I taught her terribly well.

“You know what I realized, if you drop me off you I can just leave you with the car, that way you can take care of your marriage better”

“Yes on the car, but why do you keep calling it that? Being into pottery isn’t the same as being married.”

“I call it that because you’re married to the game girl.” That line was 2 months in the works, it was my crowning achievement when it came to silly set ups, and the execution had her angry. I was so proud of myself, this felt better than the shower this afternoon. Maybe I didn’t have to take this trip afterall, maybe I could just stay, for the first time in a long time, it felt like I was intimate with someone again. What if this trip is me running away from what could be. Sitting through the thought, I couldn’t help but pain my face with the emotions on my mind, she noticed, fuck.

“You okay hun? You don’t actually go you know, just stay here with me.” I thought about this seriously, why was I going halfway

across the world today, and will it be worth it? All I know is that it felt right, not a sacrifice, but a story that needs to be lived through, I've spent too long being serious, it's time that I do something outlandish, something bizarre, that's what younger me would've wanted, to be an absolute fucking icon.

"You're so right, but I also know that I NEED to do this, I can't explain it but I feel this deep thing."

"Deep haha, just how deep are we talking here"

"Two Snickers deep."

As she pulled into the departures, I felt 15 again, all my words left me, and, all I could see was her scowl, as an uber driver stared us down, as if thinking that staring at us harder would make us leave sooner. Or maybe he was hungry and the news about the Snicker man got out. Fucking TikTok man. I dropped the window and waved his window down, before throwing a Snickers at his nose. Boop. He drove away confused. I don't think he knew whether this counted as something he should be happy or angry at. He's learning how to happy good job.

I twiddled my thumbs for a few seconds, with my fingers interlocked. Instead of saying anything I looked back at her, with devotion in mind, and leaned in close, my hand on her inner thigh, the other at the back of her head, we broke away when I needed to breath, and opened the car door, her eyes filled with wanting.

The airport is not a place for people; it's a place for businessmen who love robots.

Everything that used to be an awkward conversation has now been transformed into an electronical dooze fest, check in is on the phone, tickets are on the phone, complaints, refunds, mistakes, all of it now on the phone. I'm a nerd, and I love technology. But for the sake of living more freely I've decided that I will not give in to this mess, and for that reason I have what I call, a crap phone – an older generation iPhone, no case, bright

red, the special edition HIV edition, with scratches all along the edges. People always ask me why I don't have a case and the best answer I've found is that it's my way of hoping that my phone breaks so that I don't bother getting another, my way of leaving the grid for the rodeo in Texas, or some Costa Rican farmland. Anyways, I checked in with the immobile robotic passport grungler, and walk through the semi-automated security check and before I knew it, I'm waiting at my gate. Boredom, my nemesis.

Sat, in front of the gate I anxiously looked around for an excuse to not think about my life, my choices, or anything in particular. Thankfully, I heard laughter, obnoxious, high-pitched laughter, shrill – like a bird chirping loudly. Heiheihei.

Like a pig's nose heading for truffles, I'd imagine, I went straight for the laughter. It was a mechanical reflex.

You know that feeling of absolute dread, when you leave your things out in public and wonder if anyone is going to steal it? I feel the opposite. Take my shit I beg you, rob my ass. Do it. Is what I say to myself, just imagine the adventure that would bring.

But no, I walked up to the wine bar section across from the Tim Hortons to find 5 women. There's this thing I saw on a detective show once where you can tell how long people have known each other based on how congruently they dress, not identically, that would be absurd, but the little things, like matching accent colors, or textures, like a painting fitting together politely. The painting could be absurd and contemporary, or a lily-colored pastel. These women were a pale teal; the type I'd imagine the happiness of living in Wales might feel like.

I sat at a table next to theirs, enjoying the laughter, wondering how I was going to break into the conversation. "Hate to bother you all but I have to ask, which wine made you all so happy?" The women looked over, for a second I felt like I was going to get lashed dungeon style. Whip whip dead. But instead, the woman I

will later get to know as Elena, a blonde woman with a gentle smile and a strong nose looked at me blankly for a second before her face melted into a huge grin.

"It was the house white! Best deal in the airport, and trust us, Anne-Marie cross checked all the prices."

"Wow awesome thank you!" I replied, walking over and ordering before sitting back down.

"I have to ask, what're the odds you've all known each other for over a decade? It feels like you're sisters." Sisters was impossible because this was the most Toronto assortment of women that would be the gold standard of an equity diversity poster, there was a Jamaican, a Korean, a white Scottish looking lady, a Filipina, and a Brazilian. Where else in the world would this work? Incredible.

"How did you know! No one's actually guessed that right before." Dumb founded I looked at them all, after an attentive stare at each of them for the hint of a lie, I made up a guess as to how that could even be remotely possible. Am I high again.

"Of course not! Because you're all adopted by the same parents." I replied, faking confidence as if it was somehow stickered onto their clothes for the world to see. We're related.

"On a serious note, you must be shitting me, no way, I was joking."

"Oh no, we're completely serious." said Elena again.

"Do you think they'd adopt a 36-year-old grown man with daddy issues?" I asked. They laughed so hard one of them snorted the wine. I did it, I was in.

"That won't work, but how about we become your godmothers come join us." I purposely punched the air a little, as a grown man, in an airport, life can hardly get much better than when a group of fun-loving women twice your age invite you to a wine social. Whoop whoop.

"What're your names?"

“Dorothy, Anne-Marie as you know, Scarlett, Star, and Iara.”  
“Nice to meet you all, I’m heading to Kyoto to look at a pretty tree.” I’m very bad at hiding the plot.

“Trees huh? That’s sweet, you look like more of a Cancun type to us.” Said Anne-Marie, with a playful smile, she knew she was making fun of me. Fuck you Anne-Marie.

“Right! You would think so, but no, what about the sisters, where are you all off to? A sister convention in Idaho?”

“No convention in Idaho, that’s in Nebraska, every year we get together, tell our wives and husbands to get lost, and do something for the soul, for the polaroid picture. This year, we’re going bird watching in Kenya.” Scarlett said proudly she clearly was responsible for the planning of the trip, no, it was more than that, it was her idea to go bird watching, wasn’t it? I bet it was, white women man.

“It was your idea to do this wasn’t it, Scarlett? Why do I get the feeling that it was your turn to pick this year’s trip.”

“I really wanted to see flamingos.” She said proudly, an incredibly broad smile taking over her face, this woman smiles with her eyes. Flamingo lady.

We kept drinking and laughing. Before I knew it I heard my name on the intercom. These women weren’t lightweights they really knew how to make a grown man cry. Of laughter.

“It was nice to meet you all, lets keep in touch as an adopted son I feel obliged to join you all on a trip.”

“Lets! Here take my info down” said the mom of the group, I grabbed her contact and hobbled towards my gate like a drunk toddler, if it was up to me I would have thrown my carry on through groups of people like bowling balls, but I left my things next to my gate unattended, what a wonderful life.

I sat down in my seat 10 minutes later, without having been chastised by anyone at all. I think my brilliant smile took care of it. That and the candy bar I gave to the flight attendant. As we

took off, soaring through the air like a majestic metal bird, I thought about the wonderful, tasteful, bald spot, and ginger afro of Louis CK. He had this wonderful bit that I don't perfectly remember, where he talks about enjoying the best parts of being human, enjoying the little things, remembering that even delayed flights aren't just a privilege but an absolute blessing, Oh No, are you telling you are 30 minutes delayed before you fly at hundreds of kilometers per hour, like absolute magic? That comedic bit followed him flapping his arms like a bird. If I wasn't seated close to the eleventh most beautiful man, I've seen in my entire life I probably would've also done the chicken dance in solidarity with the plane. Good thing I was sitting next to the twelfth hottest woman I've ever seen.

I booked the direct flight to Tokyo; I couldn't help it. I was on Air Canada's Flight 001. For some reason I assumed that this flight would be reserved for our neighbours, like New York or Miami. Or more aptly within Canada, not to the other side of the world. But no, it was directed to Japan. Lucky for me I had all these credit card points that I could use, so instead of sitting with the common citizens I sat in Business. Correction, I slept in business class. You'd think I'd get into the Mile High Club on this flight, and, honestly, I thought so too, but no I was just incredibly optimistic from all of the wonderful wine and laughter. It was a one-way ticket, and, for what was between the 10<sup>th</sup> and 40<sup>th</sup> time in my life I felt like I was going on an adventure.

## Chapter 3

I woke up to the meal service, and as I peeled off my sleeping mask and blinked aggressively at the stewardess, I felt a blasting headache make old timey pre-drone warfare in my skull. The hours came, went, and before long I felt naked and afraid again, like all of this was real, and that the world would see me for what I really was, not some sort of adventurer but a lost man with a hangover dealing poorly with divorce. No, I never tattooed that on my forehead, I was fine. I do wonder what it would mean to get a tattoo like that, unlike writing code or a book, this would be final, no more edits, raw on skin. And then, if someone wanted to read my story off my back I'd have to lie down for minutes or hours after ripping my shirt straight off. Either I design and wear a transparent backed shirt, which, I don't think I have the shoulders for, or, I guess the ripping thing, which sounds expensive, I'd have to think about this a little more before getting Inked. That's what the kids say, yes. Getting Inked bro.

I debated for a while whether I wanted to get another drink to fix the headache, which, after thinking about it further, I decided I definitely shouldn't.

This is an adventure that will require my whole soul, it will require all of my faculties. Instead, I decided to pull my phone out of my pocket, connect to the Wifi on a plane. There's Wifi on a plane. Scrolling past my weird notes, I found the one labelled tree. Opening it I saw the saved Claude link I used to research where I'm going, AI is going to be the death of us, but until then I will abuse it politely. The shrine I was going to go see wasn't in Tokyo, it simply made more sense to fly there. No, I'll be landing there then taking my time to travel across Japan until I ceremoniously grace the presence of the tree. Probably, I don't know, or maybe I'll just go right away I haven't decided yet. It was one of those super touristy places, Fushimi Inari-taisha, it has a bamboo garden, as well as thousands of red gates leading you through a path in the mountains. Incredible. Imagine if we had this back home in Toronto, then we could have the Japanese flying in to see our bamboo, which, I guess already happens but for skiing and nature. Court Adjourned.

What's funny is after talking to the LLM for almost an hour, I was no closer to figuring out where this tree was, it was truly surprising me how hard it was to find a tree. Tree in a forest, ha. Unfruitful in my main conquest, I dove into the history of the place, not Japan, the mountain of red gates. It was formed in the year 711, just like the fluorescent, loud, almost casino like cheap eats mecca of Japan. All hail egg sandwiches.

Unlike the store, this mountain doesn't have sound effects, instead it's dedicated to making offerings to the money and prosperity god. The area was known for high yielding rice fields, in an effort to bring this good fortune beyond gluten-free delights, into the business of flooring, doorknobs and accounting for to name a few, businesses and people hoping to win the money game buy the red gates that you see on Instagram as offerings. Really quirky business expenses for sure.

Suddenly, this heavy, dark, feeling, washed over me, my back glistened with sweat and my eyes shrunk to the back of my skull.

*What if the tree I am flying to see has been turned into a gate?*

What if it's gone?

I punched the help wanted button with my thumb and held the button, unwilling to let this idea be real. My savior materialized as if she's been watching me flail for hours. Lucky woman.

"Hey chocolate man? Are you doing okay? You look a little, unwell is the polite word." she asked, with a degree of professional restraint you could palpate, this was definitely not going to be my day. I forgot about the chocolate bars I gave out. Does that make this awkward? Oh well. Gonna overshare.

"I had a horrible realization that's making me to feel like absolute shit."

"I'm so sorry to hear that, can I ask what happened?"

"This is going to sound absurd, if it didn't hurt so much I wouldn't share, really, but I'm heading to Kyoto on an environmental mission, and I'm worried that I'm too late. Do you ... What's your name sorry?"

"Jennifer."

"Jennifer. Do you believe in fate Jennifer?"

"I don't believe in coincidences. That's for sure." She said, the professional restraint lifting like the wrapping off of a delightful 7/11 egg sandwich, she wanted an excuse to be delighted. She wanted to be taken on a stupid silly ride through my way of thinking.

"If you would've asked me before this year, I would've told you that I didn't and that the world sucks, but the more I live on my own terms the more I feel like life is happening for me." I said, as she shifted her weight so that she was leaning into our conversation, giving space on the opposite side of the aisle. Her

hair was done up politely, but through the blonde hair you can almost make out small streaks of strawberry. I continued,

“This has been an amazing year for me, and the reason I’m heading to Japan is to better understand what it means to human in some part, through nature. But not the type you imagine, not sitting in an expensive hotel or resort and hiking, but by building out a pokedex of the most spiritual spaces in the world, the ones that speak to me personally.” Wow I didn’t know that’s what I was doing.

“That sounds incredible, but then why do you feel so bad?” She asked, a fair point. I guess I have to be honest with her then.

“One of the first places I want to go is the Fushimi Inari-taisha, there was this one tree I saw in a photo, and it draws me in. But I go to thinking about it and I realized that there’s a change that by the time I go the tree might very well be chopped down and turned into one of the red gates.”

I braced and winced, I knew that sounded childish and stupid, and it was probably all the drinking causing me to feel like shit, but I couldn’t help but hope that maybe she’ll be sympathetic. Maybe she’ll feel sympathetic enough to .. no get your head out of the gutter. But instead of acting the way I thought she would, her face broke into a smile, with the corner of her eyes forming almost a saddened expression. Something about it made it feel like she’s been here before. She was young, probably in her late thirties, she’s working for Air Canada on a coveted line, either her she knows people from the industry, or she’s fought really hard for this job. Most people tend to start on small local north American flights on cheaper airlines, not flight 001 on a national airline.

As if she was reading my mind, “I haven’t had the chance to do exactly what you’re doing but there was this time when I thought I understood exactly what I didn’t want, I was so determined and focused, so I felt proud to avoid some of the

things that made me happy. I've only recently started to remember the person I could've been."

It was my turn to smile gently, the corners of my eyes reflecting hers in a way that made the blaring of the airplane incomprehensible, my exhale was strained, I felt my shoulders relax a little. I wanted to understand her better. Who she was becoming, and who she used to believe herself to be.

While we weren't making much eye contact while we talked, our eyes met, and as we continued looking at each other a sense of understanding and closeness landed. I couldn't find words again, and usually I was good at finding funny things to say. I was usually really good at making people laugh.

"Let me know if you need anything" she said as she turned away and walked towards the galley, turning off my request light. Her figure held tight by her uniform.

For the remainder of the flight I sat with the discomfort all schoolboys share with fortune 500 executives, wondering whether I should ask her out or not. The devil's advocate here was complicated and murky, after all, she's likely not single, not a woman like that, fuck knowing my luck she might very well be happily married, but then again, she also travels so much that she might be single, and with all the social media brain rot maybe she's also finding it hard to understand people. And then even if I did ask her what would we even do, maybe a night out on the town? That could be fun. And I guess as long as I'm polite and not a complete stumbling mess, I don't see why she'd think of me as a creep.

I stepped off the plane, saying an awkward goodbye to her as I did so. Japan, here I come! I picked up my suitcase from the conveyor and filled out the paper-based immigration and declaration forms that Japan has you do. You'd think this would be done by robots, but clearly not. As I stepped out into the pastel-colored arrivals area behind the meek transition doors, I

felt a deep-seated frustration. I could've done it. I'm a grown man with a paid off boat home and divorce trauma I'm better than chickening out of asking a woman I connected with for her phone number. I made a left and then a right, following the brightly colored lines on the ground to the subway, as I stood on the escalator, I felt a polite, restrained tap on my left shoulder. That's it I was being arrested, it's been a good run Japan.

"Looks like we're going the same way." Jennifer said, a little restraint and what I could almost code as a tinge of excitement coloring her voice. Her cheeks flushed a little. How does that song go? It's getting hot in here, so take off all your clothes. Hoh hoh hot. I really hope I didn't sing that out loud.

"Looks like we are! I thought the airline staff took some sort of complimentary fancy shuttle to the city?"

"Well, yes, but also no. It's a decently far trip and I wanted to go out into the city before settling in."

We got off the escalator and got to the most Japan like invention, subway doors that look kind and forgiving with seemingly no gate, but that scream and lock you inside if you don't tap your card to pay. In a country of social pressure this is effectively suicide. We both tapped our apple wallets on the pedestal and breezed through.

Standing side by side waiting for the train, she brushed up against my arm with hers. Was that an accident? Probably.

"So how long are you staying in Tokyo for?" I asked.

"I'm here for 70 hours, so just shy of 3 days."

"I bet you must be sick of Tokyo by now, seeing that you're here every week."

"It's only been a month that I'm on this route, I got really lucky, I won a lottery system during the assignment of this route during a corporate party."

"Wow you're so lucky! I thought you had some sort of connections to be doing this route so young."

“What’re you implying?” She said, playfully.

“I’m implying it’s my second time in Japan and I still haven’t had good sushi.”

“You’re joking, lucky for you that’s my favorite thing to eat in this city, each time I’ve been I go on a bit of a binge.” She said sheepishly.

“I don’t know the word binge, do you mean, like, binge music with the head throwing and stuff?”

“No no that’s grunge, I like eating lots when I get the chance.” The subway doors opened, and we stepped in, I waved to the open seat and she sat down, looking around the rest of the tourists looked normal, not the type that actually need the seat, so I sat right down next to her. Whether it was the tightness of the seating in a country of people of smaller stature, or maybe the thought of sushi is an aphrodisiac, because our legs melted into each other. I think I’m in love with another possibly married woman. She smelled good.

“I’m definitely lucky for sure. Would you believe me if I said I didn’t have a plan beyond the flight?” I asked, laughing a little as I said it.

“Why am I not surprised?” She replied.

“How tired are you? I know it’s early afternoon, but you must be exhausted from working the past 15 hours.”

“Are you saying I look tired?”

“No, no, not at all. I’m inviting myself to sushi and working out whether it’ll be a lunch or dinner thing.” I said in a quieter voice, man this train is quiet.

“How about we start with a strong matcha and then decide from there?”

The sun was shining through the windows, and I forgot how normal this city looks.

“I’ve been here before, once. But whenever I think Tokyo, I always picture these infinite skyscrapers and a cyberpunk theme,

not tasteful neighbourhoods of buildings about 4 floors tall in slight variations of soft yellows and oranges. It's an incredibly dense city, a beautiful city. And fuck is it hot. A masochistic city where grown-ups wear suits in the heat, eating a brief lunch while fighting for a moment of rest between pointless tasks and objectively alcoholic bosses." Shit I said that last part out loud. Oops.

"I knew you had opinions but that was. A view." She said laughing, raising her eyebrows at me. Of course, she wants to take in more of my breath-taking self. We sat in silence for a few stations; arms now pressed against each other. I looked over the advertisements hanging over the handles of the train, there was one for the subway system and I'm guessing how amazing it was. The person was dressed in some sort of train conductor uniform.

"Hey look is that you on the ad? I didn't know you were famous" I giggled. Manly giggle.

She opened her eyes briefly, smiled, and closed hers again.

"We are getting off at Shinagawa." She told me.

We are getting off there. Haha. Wow I knew I was lucky but man, I'm starting to think things are going almost too well. I have a boat, I'm in Japan, I met a cute girl. I'm about to eat aphrodisiac sushi if things get any better, I'll have to be admitted to the hospital for Markadukitis. As the tourists gradually came off the train, they were replaced by the two types of people in Japan, those who did everything socially correct, and those who correctly set themselves up to be counter cultured. The cultured wore a basic t-shirt and jeans, like me, fashionable but contained. An alternative cultured look included collared shirts and blouses, along with suits depending on their jobs. Boring middle class stuff, and beyond that there were the crazy rich people wearing all sorts of odd-looking designer, as well as the misfit uniform. Before I die, I have to try out the misfit uniform, I think just like working retail in high school, it should be a necessary right of

passage. Yes, to wear chunky shoes with a platform at least 6cm thick, incredibly baggy pants with too many pockets and chains or really short skirts or both. I before I knew it I was sketching out a business plan for a short skirt covered in pockets, all interconnected with chains. I'd call this next venture something edgy, like vegans against nazis or something like that. No those are the German vegans, in Japan it'd have to be something to do with, well, I don't really know. I always thought that Japanese outfits weren't really all that real, all the short skirts, and aggressive make up. A look that wouldn't be complete without signature new age self-harm style, where someone wears an eyepatch, or a band aid across an arm or a neck or face.

So yeah, while there were the boring people like me, the rich people, the bandaid edgies, there was one more sub-category I was particularly enamoured with: older women with bright green, pink or purple hair. What made them unique was that they lived and worked and just existed as normal everyday people. I would stand to argue, were the real revolutionaries, showing up in cultured places showing their distaste for order in a semi-permanent way that screams, this was my decision. Fuck you, I will not be the average aging person, death is a lie, I murdered him, I will strangle the joy out of life if I have to, and I'll start with this glowing beacon of joy, my bright purple hair. Or something like that, but in Japanese.

We got off the subway and swam against the current of what felt like an upstream flood of Japanese. I asked Jennifer what her hotel name was and became the designated Dora, responsible for getting us there safely. We literally went under a bridge, around the daytime drunks and straight to the hotel. I think trying to read a language I absolutely could not understand counted as the riddle. Walking by vending machine, after vending machine, three vending machines, I resisted the urge to press all the buttons like I do in elevators and instead turned all of my finite attention on

making sure that my drowsy princess doesn't get run over by bicycles or cars, or me. As we dragged the suitcases I noticed these really rhythmic noises our suitcases made. both like a low waon woan waaah.

I started to skibiti-pop beep boop along with the sounds. I became the rebel I always dreamed of. For a second the vibes were immaculate and I was transported back to the first time I threw a chocolate bar at a pedestrian.

But that feeling was short lived. Because almost like the incarnation of, not a devil but like some sort of bad thing, I started getting dirty looks. First from a fellow white person, and then, I swear on Guinness, one of the older women with the hairstyle I respected so much decided that I should be tripped. Just like meeting your idols only to find out they're not who you expected, I got a gut-wrenching reality check that nearly ended with my face in the concrete. Fucking fuck. The only thing that saved me from crashing straight down was Jennifer suitcase. She really was a miracle.

Ten minutes later we arrived at a nondescript commercial hotel, but then we entered the lobby and suddenly we were transported into the wilderness, almost what I imagined a resort in the countryside would feel like. Sophisticated. There was an incredibly tasteful garden in the centre of the space. The ceilings were elevated; the walls were a tasteful mix of light and dark browns with a Danish construction. I take it back I want to be a flight attendant doing the Toronto to Japan flight in my next life.

We walked up to the front desk and checked in. No funny business happened, except I could feel her get a little nervous, little things like the pacing of her movements, slight flushing of cheeks. I did my best to look cool and stoic, just my average Tuesday. Yes, it is. Stepping into the elevator a silence took over us, the higher the elevator went the stronger the tension built. I tried to think of a joke but came up short, something something

Otis. I kept that masterpiece to myself. My adrenaline peaked when we started to walk down the hallway. Fiddling with the key card, she dropped it.

“Clumsy fingers” she laughed it off awkwardly, her movement slightly sharper than I expected. She must be a little anxious too. We both went to pick it up and hit our heads. Grabbing it, I utter a little too loudly, “I win.” Tapping the card and pushing the door open, I held the door open from the outside for her to walk in. And then I got impatient and we both walked in at the same time and bumped into each other. Our eyes locked on each other, and we dropped the luggage as if on cue.

“You win, huh.”

She said, almost whispering. Her perfume was intoxicating. My hand naturally found its way around her waist.

“I’ll have you know I’m really good at Mario Kart.”

“That’s good to know, because I’ll ruin you at the arcade. Later.”

“Okay fine, but later.”

I practically heard her heart beat out of her chest. I wondered whether it was okay to kiss her. Probably not, right?

I began what I call the should I stay or should I kiss ritual.

Our eyes danced from looking at each other’s eyes, to each other’s lips, I led with my eyes and she followed. Okay it was a go.

She bit her lip looking at me adoringly, giggled a little, and I leaned in, closing the distance.

One hand caressed and held her the back of her head while my brain did absolutely everything it could to hold back a joke it knew would ruin the tension. Winner winner chicken Katsu. I’m not gonna say it, I’m not gonna say it. No. No. No. But what if. No.

The only thing keeping my tongue from uttering the worst joke of my life was her tongue and lips, they brought me back to present, and before I knew it my joke circuit shut off. One arm held her head, while the other made it way down her

lower back, along the edges of her outline to grip her ass. What a firm perfect, butt, I knew she worked out but, she was a reformer girl wasn't she?

Her fingertips traced my forearms, along my biceps, up to my head settling her hands on my back. I was proud of my wide back. We pressed against each other, her skirt enveloping one of my legs. I broke the kiss, and brought a hand up to her hair, pulling her head back as I lost myself in her fragrance. Nibbling from her collarbone up along her neck. I made a little bit of a show if it for her, but not on purpose, she just tasted so very sweet. Mhmm. The more I understood her the more I began to understand her bit by bit, a Pilates woman with great taste in both perfume and men.

As she began to really enjoy herself, I shifted my hands down to her ass and lifted her up, causing her skirt to rise. Her work skirt was so tight that this didn't quite work, but we were both so determined, so I grabbed her by her lower back and ass, growling as I did, making her scream. "What was it that Godzilla said before he started to terrorize Japan?" "Probably Roar." She said, looking all confused. Stop that comedy brain. The bed was just another hotel bed. Nothing magical. Dropping her over the sheets it became perfect. She squealed as she fell, looking like she already forgot the Godzilla joke, I took a moment to take her in, her cheeks red and flush, hair messier than I ever thought I'd see when I first met her.

She was still wearing her work skirt and top, makeup nearly as pristine as when I first met her. Fuck was I lucky.

Chicken Winner Katsu something.

She sat up looking at me with these large, adorable eyes of hers. I leaned back over her and kissed hard again, her hands trailing towards my pants. As she squeezed, my inhibitions of treating her gently fell apart and my hands began learning her properly. I felt

her chest up, noticing the outlines of her nipples as they hardened, pinching until I felt them pressed through her top.

By now her hands found their way through my defenses, her hands wrapped around me. My hand went on her head as I led her mouth to where I needed her to go. She was such a good girl I told her. I felt her smile as she became more determined. I had to stop her.

“Do you have another change of work clothes? What if we make this set dirty?”

“They have dry cleaning here.” She moved away and serious all of the sudden. I began feeling a little worried, maybe I did something wrong?

“Can I be completely open with you?”

“Of course.”

“This isn’t normal for me, well for the old me. I don’t know what I’m doing.” She looked so sure of herself a few seconds ago, but all the sudden she didn’t she looked, the right word wasn’t hesitant, no, she looked vulnerable, not scared, but like she was about to ask for something. The kind of question you can only really ask someone you don’t actually know unless you met them a few hours ago.

“I want you, but I want to keep these work clothes on.”

“Oh, I thought you were going to ask something crazy. That’s so hot of course.” I breathed a deep sigh of relief. Come here I said smiling. I watched her transform right back into the seductress I first met, watching first her shoulders drop, then her jaw relax, a smile form on her lips. But a second later, I pulled away from our kiss. Are you okay she asked, with her shoulders back in defense.

“This time I won’t take your clothes off, but since I won, we’re showering together.” She smiled, her defenses fell faster this time, she smiled and excitedly nodded her head. Deal she said.

## Chapter 4

I woke up butt naked on my front. What's with me and nudity I started to wonder, and where was my night-time speedo. I looked over to my right and the I saw the sunset start to fall outside the window over a sprawling assortment of glass and concrete buildings. Looking over to my left there was Jennifer passed out, almost drooling. She must've changed out of her work clothes at some point into a baggy top and panties. She was exhausted, rightfully so, she looked so cute drooling into the pillow. She was a drooling beauty queen. Our clothes were scattered across the floor, I always found this part kind of emasculating, chasing my underwear and socks. I do like obstacle courses though that's true! I'll shower later, still waiting for my prize. I collected her work clothes and put them in the room's dry-cleaning bag. Realizing we didn't even have each other's phone numbers I scribbled a note to her on the pad, *I'm grabbing a snack, here's my number. +1(647)-454-1564. Message me when you're up.* I grabbed a keycard and sneaked out of the room, I looked at the room number to be sure of where and where I was coming back to, the

adrenaline completely wiped my memory of where the fuck I am. Maybe I didn't rooie myself, maybe my friend was fucking with me the entire time? No. It couldn't have been just adrenaline that night. What a marvelous feeling, *ignorance*.

Down the elevator, out the front door, and into the brilliance of Japan. The country of my magical tree. I was ready for adventure. As I started walking, I started to think, the things that would make this adventure brilliant is to start with finding the convenience store that matches the founding year of the mountain I'll be visiting. It was beautiful out and warmer than I expected, I started to sweat under my sweater. The buildings looked like they were built out of LEGO bricks. I walked by a coffee vending machine, and I finally let myself give into my urges, I pressed ALL the buttons down. Yes. That's the way it should be done. My headache was gone, I felt great. This place was too clean, it was uncanny, and I considered whether it made sense to start littering what would happen, would I go to jail? I'll ask a local. Not randomly off the street, but when I go out later, talk about a stupid perfect opener. The convenience store was crowded with 3 white families exploring the aisles, I went straight for the things I wanted, an egg sandwich, I got two, along with two pops and, woah they have cooked pieces of chicken breast in a vacuum sealed bag. Incredible. I couldn't, not, grab a chocolate bar, I had to have one, who would I be otherwise? Lining up there were a few incredible faces, a black American couple by the feel of it, both wearing their most anime shirts holding hands, an average looking Japanese guy with a grey backpack, and this young girl wearing platforms that added 4 inches to her height. I'm of the opinion that instead of leg lengthening surgery, people should start buying shoes with thick Heels. Buy the Japanese platforms and wear them proudly the same way a bald man wears a baseball cap or a wig.

I paid, bowed a little, I guess you're supposed to do that? Mumbled in Japanese and proudly stumbled my way back to the hotel. There's something ridiculous about vending machines, I mean they feel so intimate yet insensitive. What do you mean I press a button and get the thing I want without anyone knowing except for my credit card company? And if I use cash, no one knows except for maybe God and the government that's tracking me through the cameras. Hi police.

It's not the same as going to the grocery store, or getting something delivered, or even pulling a beer out of the fridge. You have to leave the safety of your home, or work, a place you know and instead bring yourself to this little metal box in an open place, and choosing what you really want, do you want a coffee, or a few extra calories? Cigarettes? The more I think about it the more I understand why some vending machines in Japan sell the most absurd things like used socks or panties.

A vending machine is really a tasteful contract you make with the ephemeral. I want it all. So, I press all the buttons again. But then I look over this glorious pale beauty and decide I actually wouldn't mind a can of black coffee. I wait until the colors on the buttons turn off, and then I tap my credit card, selecting my special request. My card gets charged for hundreds and hundreds of Yen, what the fuck. All the cans drop out, and I realized this might be the Japanese equivalent of my candy bar scenario, where I could give them away, except this happened against my will. Plus, these are heavy, metal, little cans. I can't just throw cans at people. Well, I can, but I don't want to go to jail, mom I'm kidding. I pulled my sagging pants up, straightened my jaw, gave myself a motivational pep talk and decided on doing the obvious thing, becoming a free vending machine salesman. I stood there, giving out cans, I bet people thought I was an American. Fuck I'm not an American. The first person that walked by was an older

man, one of the suit people, his head was down, he looked exhausted.

“Hi, would you like a free coffee? It is a promotion.” I said, as he completely ignored me and walked by.

“Hi, would you like a free drink? I accidentally bought too many.” I said to another 10 people. I got 3 avoidances, 1 smile, one scowl, and the rest were white people who took my cans. Take my cans, baby. I got lost in one conversation with a couple from Arizona who, while at first said no, kept talking to me. I became determined to give them the cans, maybe they could take over my job. Working sales is harder than I remember, especially for free stuff. The couple mentioned how they’re here because they both absolutely love the idea of Japan, how they watch the animes and read mangas, the woman spent a semester studying Japanese in college but never had the chance to experience it. They’ve been planning this trip all year, from the hotel to the bars, and Disney, all the way to the train times. Incredible people. In an effort to get them to stop talking I asked them if they also planned sex. Unfortunately, that only got them talking more, they accounted for everything it was actually somewhat incredible. I take it back this couple was awesome. I asked them what they were up to tonight and they said that this was the one night with a hole in their intense schedule, they had a reservation that fell through because a chef they were following fell ill. It was such a small restaurant that the whole thing was closed. Better than booger sushi, I said. That was actually the name of a delicacy, a type of sea urchin.

“You must be fucking with me.”

“Yes, we’re totally fucking with you.”

“Well, I’m staying here with someone for a few days, I think she has a specific place in mind, let me see if I could turn this into a double date.” I said, and, after pulling out my phone to get their info I saw a text from an unknown number. *Just woke up, getting in*

*the shower soon :)* I dropped the cans next to the vending machine and hurried back.

Feeling fresh and reenergized we sat eating our egg sandwiches cuddled up naked, for a while.

“Best egg sandwich of my LIFE.”

“10/10 ambience.”

“Where did you get these?”

“Come on guess.”

“I really don’t know I don’t want to guess”

“7’11”

“Wow. I thought it was just hype.”

“Are you telling me you’ve never had an egg sandwich in Japan before.” I asked incredulously, I watched the glory of the bright yellow mayo laden filling as it soaked the crustless white bread smushed between her fingers. I didn’t know I could get this turned on by food before.

“Never. I was never an egg girl.”

“That doesn’t sound like an egg-citing life. Shucks.”

“I’m glad I could be your first.” I said, squeezing her a little. This felt too cute, I decided to break the comfort with operation blowing raspberries, fart noises on her stomach were made, and then I was chased around the hotel room, anxious to not get more egg smushed on me. I read that egg is a great skin moisturizer, not sure if my skin’s rejuvenated after minutes of eggs-foliation. A lifetime later, she finally got dressed, did what women do, we left the hotel. I held up my phone to my eyeline like a grandfather terrible eyesight, and, with the location of dinner put into my Maps. I led us forward towards another subway station.

On the way, I decided to modify our trip to pass by the Mecca, the place of the sacred sandwich. But on the way, we also passed the intimate vending machine. The stack of cans was still there. 3 left in my stash. I picked one up and drank from it.

“What’s wrong with you?” she asked, I think she was reconsidering our romance then and there.

“Oh, I bought them all earlier and was trying to give them all away when you messaged me. They’re technically ours now, you can think of them as a sort of public utility.”

“Okay that makes more sense I thought you were stealing.”

“That’s not who I am! Wow. Offended.”

“I’ll take that electrolyte one.”

I handed it to her, and after flapping my hands at the beauty of the sandwich homestead, we entered the politely evil subway doors and stood out on the platform. Just like old times 10 hours ago. We exited at one of the major rail stations, and, instead of leaving it, followed a series of really busy corridors deeper into the labyrinth. We passed restaurants on our left and right, tightly composed of everything you can imagine, from katsu’s and noodles to sushi and takeaways. Some of them just looked Japanese. The colors were unexpected for an underground, it was filled with woods, and yellows, all with large bright colored signed some handwritten some painted over. The last thing I expected was to end up at a sushi place under a train station, but Jennifer was the sushi grunge. We sat down at a counter, and I didn’t understand why this was the spot, but it was the spot. We scanned the QR codes and used the menu on the phone to order. I wanted to defer to her judgement, but, looking over the menu, a few things got me incredibly excited. First, there was rare beef sushi, I mean rice and beef built this body, plus it was uncommon. Then sea urchin, what would that taste like, and the usual culprits like Salmon, Tuna, and then some smaller sides. I pressed send to kitchen and looked over to Jen, taking a peak at her phone I noticed that was still perplexed with the menu, looking at it in Japanese.

“Wait can you read Japanese?” I asked.

“No, not really, I can make out some of the symbols but nothing major and definitely not everything.”

“I bet you watch anime.”

“I do; I have lots of favorites. Is it obvious.”

“I’m starting to see it.”

“I already ordered I couldn’t wait, but since you’re the grunger, what’s the best thing to get here.”

“I always go for the basics and try a little of everything.”

“That’s fair enough! I got things I thought looked exciting.”

She nodded approvingly to that, I got this fuzzy feeling in my chest, and my mind went a little blank. Was I getting sick again? Or was this what love felt like. Who cares. Looking to our right and left, I wanted to make some new friends, not to say I was bored, but wouldn’t it be cool to pull a Bourdain and like really understand on a human level where the fuck I am right now?

Adventure in a way that lets me feel like I’m just as frustrated the social norms that the locals are also pissed off at? Fuck that highway, those rich people? Horrible. I love that actor and music idol. I don’t know my father either, or of course my uncle got me a job at his manufacturing firm. Of course, I want to get black out drunk and be hung over on company time. I don’t know what I want out of my life either. You know, the human stuff.

“How do you say hi in Japanese, Konichiwa right?”

“Well, that’s what you’d say formally, but in a situation like this you should say something like Dōmo.”

“I’ve never heard that word before, okay sweet!”

I said hi to the people sitting next to us, on our left and right, they were two completely different people, the first was a man about my age, tired, with a bit of a gut and a basic baggy gray t-shirt. Whatever this man did for work, he didn’t care about how he was perceived, he could’ve been a construction worker or some sort of super serious carpenter or chef, I had absolutely no idea. I decided to keep it a mystery; he didn’t look happy.

On Jen's side there was the complete opposite, a woman well-dressed sitting with her friend, also wearing a suit, both looking like they were either gossiping about work or their husbands. And the cooler thing is they both had beers in hand, eating slowly. Laughing loudly. Fuck it they were too happy, let's not screw up their gossip session I thought.

"I don't know how good this sushi's going to be, but I'm excited. Just how did you end up finding this place?"

"The first time I came down on this flight I wanted to see more of Japan, and I had this idea, to, like, spend the 3 days travelling across the country by train. So I came to this station to take the first bullet train south. I had an hour to wait so I came down here and literally got lost, pretty much, umm, started to cry, and just when I was working up the courage to ask someone for help. Which, I rarely if ever do, I saw someone walk out of this place. Next thing I know I'm eating the best sushi of my entire life." As she finished her thought, the sushi arrived. And it looked nothing like what I've been eating back home. I lied to her; I've had sushi in Japan before. And it's the same category taxonomy of food, but a completely different beast. The rice was fragrant, with a springiness to it that's hard to describe. And the fish layed on top of the sushi here, it engulfed the meek piece of rice so much that you feel like you're eating a slice of sashimi. Each piece was charged separately, and as I grabbed, broke, and aligned the chopsticks I proudly engulfed the piece with salmon like a classy homeless man, who hasn't eaten in days.

"Holy fuck. I didn't want to give you the satisfaction, but this is absolutely incredible." I said as I ate piece after piece after piece. She was glowing with rightful with pride. Unlike my usual breakfast you can't really pillage sushi, it's more of a Godzilla situation, where you pick up the beautiful piece, politely try not to drown it in soy sauce, and then devour it like one big bite.

We sat there laughing and making noises of satisfaction, and as we continued to, we caught the attention of the chef, who, was wearing exactly what you'd expect a sushi chef to wear. He looked over to me, face expressionless, then to her, smiled, and then back to me, made what looked like an imperceptible nod, and then said very loudly.

"Are you Americans?"

We look at each and back at him and I shook my head.

"Canadians."

"We'll me I was born in Florida." Said Jennifer.

"Canadians are good." He said, going so far as to give us a big thumbs up.

"Thank you! Your sushi is incredible." She told him while I nodded my head and ate my uncommon beef sushi.

Shortly after, we paid, hobbled out in the fresh evening air and found ourselves walking down a street lined by a mixture of residential and trees.

"I want to go the to a Maid Café." She said, out of nowhere. There wasn't any skirt to stir up her imagination either she must've been thinking about it.

"Those freak me out; you really want to do that?" I asked, then thinking about it a little more for a second, a beer would be good.

"I'm open to the idea if you really wanna do it, but isn't it really really weird?"

"Well, I've never been, it'd be weird to go by myself, but with you coming with me I feel like the "weirdness" of it all drops a few points."

"If the next sushi spot blows me away, then we'll do it. And maybe if I ask nicely they'll give me a job, I'm desperate for purpose and would look so good in a mini skirt."

"You and your hairy ass, totally. I think you'd look hotter in my uniform."

“I’ll take you up on that one literally even if you might have said it as an insult to begin with.” She punched me a little, and then leaned back in, before pulling out her phone, opening the maps app and giving it to me with the next spot brightly drawn in. Just follow the path Dora

“Tu tu tu, Dora the explorer!”

“You’re weird.”

“I’m glad you noticed.”

It only took us 3 minutes to walk to the next spot she had picked out. But as we walked in and ducked under the little fabric flag, I hate to say it, but it looked almost the same as the one under the train station, except it was quieter, with only 6 seats, 3 of them filled, everyone was laughing. I take it back this place was incredible.

JAPANESE GREETING. I couldn’t make out what they were quite saying but it was loud, everyone clapped a little, and bowed. I didn’t know I was royalty but now that I think of it, I’ll start treating myself like it. Understood.

We sat, down, ordered, make out sloppily for a short while. Started to talk to our neighbors and before long the food came out. I started to lose track of time, it felt like we were always in this restaurant. This was my family, this was it.

We made our way out and walked towards the third sushi grunge spot. This one was much farther away, the maps app said 40 minutes walking or 20 minutes with the subway. We walked.

It took us 50 minutes, stopping periodically to rotate through the things humans do when they’re having a great time, full of food, and in a place they don’t know. For us it included pressing the buttons on vending machines, poorly describing how pretty and ugly some buildings were, where we’d live and definitely hate to live, and periodically stopping to make out like teenagers.

“Let me guess about this next one we’re going to, it was the romantic restaurant you went to with a past partner, and the

reason you come back to Japan is to revisit the feelings you have for them.”

“That’s some really sad and sobby sounding crap. Hahaha. Thankfully not.”

“Fair enough, my needy self-needed to come out into the open a little. Is it simply because you saw it on a blog or something?”

“Even better! I had this one friend in high school; she was from Tokyo staying in my city through one of those host family programs. And she taught me all about Japan. This is their restaurant. It’s really special to me.”

“Wow that’s incredible. Wait does that mean I’m meeting your best friend today?”

“Unlucky for you... No, you’re not. She’s in the UK right now visiting her sister. But her dad is the chef. So, in a way, I guess we’re meeting the parents today.”

“I’m going to need a little something to make sure I can get through something like this. I’m great with parents, but being this full of food already is going to make it hard to appreciate great sushi. We don’t have a reservation, do we?”

“No reservation. But it’s getting a little late so I’m hoping to get there at least half an hour before they close.”

“That we can do. Wow. This is incredible. Thank you.” I said that honestly. I wanted to make a joke, that’s what I typically do. But in a moment like this, I, just couldn’t. It’s not quite a ceremony in the typical sense, but no, I needed to present my better self. I can do this.

Before long we were standing in front of what looked to my ignorant white man eyes the same thing as the last place, except the flag looking cover thing looked a little more washed, and I couldn’t really hear any laughter standing outside the restaurant. With a deep breath from us both, I opened the door as she stepped in.

## Chapter 5

The sake was warm, and it came in this little ceramic bottle, it helped because I was acting too cool. Her best friend's dad was an incredible guy, but the last thing I expected was for him to be Taiwanese. Well, it's a complicated story but in short, he has mixed feelings about his ethnicity and upbringing, rightfully so. And I found this out shortly after we walked in, sat down, and watched him prepare some sashimi, close the front door and sit with us at the table.

He's got sharp knives, so I'm really glad I decided to calm down the jokes. But then again, maybe he'd like jokes, or maybe they'd Sake.

“How long have you two known each other? You look good together. Has it been a few months now?”

Her face of surprise told everything I needed to know.

“What makes you say months?” I asked.

“It’s the way you both look unreserved and open with each other, that and it doesn’t look like the attraction died yet.” That caught me off guard, and glancing at Jen, same thing with her. I wondered what she’d say here. It’s her social capital at risk here, I’ll let her decide how long we’ve known each other for.

“We’ve known each other for a while as friends, and then he happened to catch a flight I was working, and it was like nothing’s changed.” This made me perk up, wait, no fucking way. I should get my brain checked; my memory issues are becoming absurd. No wait. No, she’s just really convincing. That was good. I would’ve said something sheepish like, yes, a few months.

“Jennifer says she’s best friend with your daughter which, makes me think you have a wife?”

“Of course I do.” Just checking you never know, maybe he has 3.

“How did you meet her?” To answer that he began by smiling a little with his eyes, his complexion looking years younger, all the sudden it felt like I was looking at a different man, somehow even less prudent, more aggressive, and with a flair for the dramatic. I say that because he tilted his head to the side a little and nodded towards our Sake cups. Having finished them, he refilled them for us all.

“I won her in a fight.” Yep, he’s a killer, he’s part of the Yakuza. Door is locked, I’m gonna die today. At least I’ll meet God, Lucy would be proud of me.

“When I was in, how you say, college, I used to Sumo.”

“So, you wore the diaper looking thing and everything!” I said, cutting him off.

“Yes. And there was this guy I hated, Kumayama. Growing up he used to push me around. I hated it. I was a spiteful young man and decided that I would find a way to beat him up. So, I spent years training sumo. I ate so much food; every day I would eat these big soups full of all the rice and vegetables you could think of. My mother was against it, but she was also I think just happy I was eating. After I’ve beat multiple local competitors, I became known at my university as the best. At the same time that guy was becoming the best at his. And like fate would have it, we matched up together in the semi-finals. I knew I would beat him I had no doubt. And I did.”

“But that doesn’t answer it, how did you meet her.”

“She’s his sister, when I won, she came up to congratulate me and, the rest is, like the Americans say, history.”

“Amazing, that is one of the most badass things I’ve ever heard.” I said loudly, clapping a little as I said it. This man is essentially a samurai.

“All these years and I never knew the story. Now people get married off of dating apps.” Jen said, downing her Sake.

This felt good. I was just drunk enough to have a slight buzz on, all the food allowing sobriety to steer the ship than the alcohol. The Dad, focused back on eating

“What was it like to eat to be a sumo? Like did you eat nothing but rice and meat? It seems expensive. And then, if that was your speciality, why start a sushi restaurant?” My mind filled with so many questions about this man.

“First off, no, I’m pescatarian, I only eat fish for protein. And it was a lots of veggie soups.”

“Now that’s something I want to try before I leave Japan. A soup like that! It could become a franchise chain.” I cut in, the sake was flowing and my social skills turned into targeted curiosity. Who what why.

“No. That already exists, its called Chanko Kirishima. And it’s run by ex-sumo wrestlers, you must try it before you leave, I agree.” He says, with a smile full of sake, spitting a little. Looking over to Jennifer, she looked a little zoned out, I wonder what she was thinking about. I squeezed her shoulder gently, smiling.

“Sorry I cut you off, what about the sushi shop then, if the ex-sumo restler custom is to start a Chanko shop, why did you start a sushi restaurant?” I asked.

Shifting in his chair, he looked over the counter to the back of the restaurant, into the back space. And, after what looked like a negotiation with himself, he nodded his head a few times to the side and then stood up all the sudden. “Stay right there.” He said and walked away for a second. A few seconds later, he came back with a stick. It was small, with a few smaller protrusions, it was semi-lunar, with a thinner and longer side.

“When I was younger, I hated the idea of working on sushi, I really enjoyed everything to do with sports, and nature. In the summers before university started, I spent my summers working on a tree farm in southern Japan. It was hard work, and I spent the days on my feet. I would go up these steep hills and make sure that small trees could continue to grow, cutting away these frustrating little plants around it. And sometimes I would get lucky enough to find Shitake growing. If I did I would, collect them and then bring them back to my workmates and I would either sell them or cook them.

Hmm.

One of the people I worked with was this small, fast man, he had these eyebrows that made him look super young and old at the same time. I still don’t know how old he is, Tamotsu Kusunoki, he showed me the best way to cook these mushrooms and over time we stayed in touch. I went off to university. I focused on Sumo. And once a week I would continue to cook the

mushrooms for my sumo friends. Cooking became something I really enjoyed doing for others.

University ended, and I couldn't find a job in the thing I wanted; it was a bad time to be an ecologist. At the time me and my girlfriend were about to celebrate our second year together, but I didn't have any money. The week leading up to it, I was running out of ideas. And then the thought to reach out to Tamotsu came up, and, he's always had a restaurant in the city, but I've never been. I told him about my problem, and without me asking, he offered to give me and my girlfriend a closed restaurant experience if I would come back the next week to help him prep a fish that was arriving for the week. It was a no-brainer. Over the years, I would help out around the restaurant on the weekends. And you know how the rest of this story goes, he gets old, wants to retire, doesn't want to sell the restaurant but also can't afford to stop. One evening after closing, he asks me if I would want to take over. I never wanted to own a business; I was coaching students during the week at the time and I really enjoyed it. It was a pleasure to serve. Banks in Japan are very complicated, so instead of taking out a loan we agreed that I would pay him off by working the restaurant and transfer the ownership like this. I blinked and now I'm 50." He finished by laughing loudly, a little melancholy showing up, along with a deep-rooted satisfaction. I was drunk, but not too drunk to not appreciate how beautiful this story was. I didn't realize that seller financing was an option in Japan, duh.

"So really this is all thanks to your wife then." Jen said playfully.

"You could say so."

I poured myself a little more sake, and stood up, looking for the Toto. I bowed to him, then bowed at the toilet. You'd think I'd have hit my head against the toilet seat, but you'd be wrong, I

hit it against the door frame. Even the toilet was beautiful, why did it smell so nice?

As much as I loved the story it was becoming a little too intimate, I wanted to escape for a second, let the dad and his daughter's best friend catch up a little. Maybe I could set up the excuse of a cigarette. Yeah, that could work. Take a quick loop, buy a pack and come back in 10 minutes.

"I'm going to step out for a cigarette." I said nodding to them, as low as I could reasonably go, what am I doing, what's wrong with me? They both smiled and nodded their heads back. The curtain was gone; he took it down. I took a left and walked towards what I could see as the faint outline of rectangular intimacy. Getting closer I saw it wasn't the type of machine with cigarette, just the drinks all over again. Fuck. No wait, next to it was another one, a smaller one that looked almost like a novelty item, not real. I'm not going to chance it. Instead of looking for a 7/11 I decided to explore further out of my comfort zone and look for the terribly named Family Mart. I hate wholesome, and this store was the perfect place to break what it means to be a family, by buying cigarettes. Yes, this feels right. I stepped out with my fresh pack of grape flavored cigarettes, I popped the flavor packet, breathed in the cancerous wonder and started to walk back towards the restaurant. Parked next to the vending machine I decided not to use was this plain looking Honda, and, next to it was this average looking Japanese guy screaming what seemed like curses at the cigarette machine. Without words, because I had none, I opened my pack and offered him one of mine, with the lighter in the other hand. I love this guy because he didn't do the whole dance of no, maybe, okay fine thanks. No, he just nodded ever so slightly and grabbed a cigarette. He said a quick flurry of Japanese, and, after a few seconds I realized he was probably telling me about the shitty machine.

“Sorry I don’t speak Japanese I said, looking at him smiling blankly.” For some reason it felt like he was more badass than he was letting on with his outfit. Its not like I thought he would hit me, but it’s the type of scowl he made with his face that turned me towards believing that this man has the capacity to beat people up.

“Vending machine is working like shit today.” He said, slowly with pauses that made me grateful he was making such an effort to speak with me.

“Yes, yesterday it made everything fall out. I decided to go to a store today.”

“Are you American.”

“No. Canadian.”

“Where are you from.” I asked, playfully, laughing as I asked.

“Japan. Japanese.”

“Thank you for the cigarette.” He said as he sat into his car, wait a second that car isn’t supposed to start like that. That was fucking loud. It sounded like someone trapped an animal inside a honda. I waved my hand down for him to lower his window, and after he spun what I realized was a manual window spinner, he looked at me with a huge grin and asked, “What’s up American?” I raised a middle finger back at him for a second, before saying. “I give you all my cigarettes for a ride.” He looked at me for a second, debating whether feeding his addiction was worth introducing a questionable looking white man into his sanctum. Then he laughed, said, “Now I am going for long ride and meet friends. Who are you.” How do you answer that? I don’t he cares what my name is or what my blood type is or childhood trauma, no, he wants to know WHO I am.

“I put pineapple on my pizza.” I said. Wait shit. Even if I come along what am I going to do with Jen and the old man?

“You’re crazy man. Okay you can come.”

“My friend is finishing dinner in restaurant there.” I pointed down the block to the restaurant without the curtain.

“Oh. Your friend has good taste. Okay I wait 5 minutes.” I wasn’t expecting that.

“Could you ... drive me to the door?” He propped the passenger door open with a slightly annoyed look.

I walked into the restaurant with a slight anxiousness, I think it may have been telepathy, or something else but they looked over as if they knew exactly what I was going to say.

“I see that you met the neighbourhood disappointment.” Said the dad. That’s one thing to say about a loud car. Then all the sudden he shifted and laughed loudly.

Yes, and I’m hoping to also become a neighbourhood disappointment, I convinced him to take us on a ride. But we’d have to go now I said, making my best effort to make puppy dog eyes at Jen. What am I doing. No, I’m not gonna do the whimper, it wouldn’t help right now.

“You’re invited too old man.” I said playfully.

“Let me close up.” He said in a final tone. This was really happening, I don’t think I had the authority to invite him. Oh well. Let’s see what happens. I think the side-effect of such a small restaurant is that he closed up lightning fast. And all the sudden we were all standing in front of the Honda.

“Taku-bō” The chef says, peering into the car with a relaxed loudness. Car smoker guy, who I guess is Takubo, suddenly straightens up a little, and sheepishly smiles a little, “A-kū” The exchange a flurry of words between each other in a language I don’t understand, as Jen wobbles a little, checking Instagram, should I, no, let’s leave her privacy no peaking, stop it.

After a short while, after she does some more phone stuff, she puts it away and looks up at me,

“Who’s getting the front seat” she asks, in what seems like the most the most convincing, sultry voice she could possibly make. I won’t give in that easy.

“Rock paper scissors for it.” I said. Raising my rock arm up, so that I could crush her scissors. She picked paper.

“Fine.” I’m glad she won; it’s the least I could do after this amazing sushi. Holy fuck was it good. Maybe I could get a nap in the backseat. I like loud noises.

We said our goodbyes which included hugs and sat inside the car. He looked over to her and revved the engine. That logically got a slap on the car from Aku. He said something that I bet was along the lines of not here. And then we drove away.

“I have to pick up my girlfriend.” He said, right before he turned up the music and put on ASAP Rocky.

## Chapter 6

We stopped for our third cigarette break in front of a short apartment building. Me and Jennifer were starting to feel the hearing loss kick in, I wasn’t sure whether he was trying to drown out the sound of engine or the other way around, but the sudden

silence felt nice. I thought this would be like a need for speed situation, but instead it's becoming more of something else. More of a karaoke.